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Editorial Guidelines

A stylebook for voice, tone and writing guidelines

WebMD health services

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Contents

About This Document 4

Content Rules A-Z 5

- Acronyms and Abbreviations 5
- Ampersand (&) 5
- Capitalization: Headlines, Subheads and Job Titles 5
  - Documents and web copy. 5
  - Job titles. 6
- Citations, Footnotes and References 6
  - Where to put the superscript in running copy. 6
  - How to format footnotes. 7
- Clichés and Filler Words 8
- Clients: How To Refer To Clients and Their Organizations 8
  - Clients. 8
  - Clients' organizations. 9
- Dashes: Em-Dash vs. En-Dash 9
- Latin Terms and Abbreviations 9
- Lists: Bulleted Lists, Numbered Lists and Punctuation Rules 10
- Parentheses 11
- Serial Comma 11

Glossary of Terms and Appropriate Use Cases A-Z 12

- A 12
  - Affect vs. Effect 12
- B 12
  - book of business 12
  - Clinical Advisory Board 12
- D 13

diabetes 13
disease names 13
E 13
e-book 13
email 13
H 13
healthcare 13
O 14
offsite, onsite 14
P 14
personally identifiable information 14
preventive 14
protected health information 14
S 14
single sign-on 14
V 15
versus 15
W 15
web, website 15
WebMD Health Services 15
wellness vs. well-being 15

About This Document

The Editorial Guidelines outlined in this document govern all written content developed by WebMD Health Services. Designed to help reinforce brand consistency across collateral, all writers and content producers—both internal and external—should reference these guidelines to ensure proper spelling, punctuation, and grammatical usage, and consistent voice and tone.

These guidelines include information on the following brand standards:

- Spelling, capitalization and punctuation rules
- Formatting rules
- Language dos and don'ts
- A glossary of proper words, terms, phrases and acronyms specific to our industry and company

To quickly navigate to a specific section, please reference the clickable table of contents above.

For more information regarding our brand identity, voice and tone, refer to our Brand Guidelines on Confluence. Here, you'll also find information about our visual design guidelines and identity.

NOTE: We use the Associated Press Stylebook as our primary style reference standard, with certain exceptions specific to our brand. If you have questions that this guide does not reference, contact branding@webmdhealthservices.com.

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Content Rules A-Z

Acronyms and Abbreviations

When listing a company or solution that uses a common acronym, spell out their name in the first mention followed by their preferred abbreviation or acronym in parentheses, unless they appear in a headline or title. In that case, do not use the abbreviation until the body copy. Use the abbreviation or acronym on all subsequent mentions.

> Example of a title followed by body copy:
>
> Our Conversation with the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention
>
> The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) explained several ways people can help maintain their physical health. One recommendation the CDC provided was that people wash their hands for at least 20 seconds.
>
> Example of body copy: The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) recommends that you wash your hands for at least 20 seconds.

NOTE: In cases where there is limited space, such as a presentation slide, use your best judgment on whether to spell out the full name of common companies.

Ampersand (&)

Do NOT use the ampersand as an abbreviation for "and." Use it only if it's part of a formal company, event, or program name, or if limited space requires it, such as in a one-pager or a presentation slide.

> Examples of appropriate use cases: Lunch & Learn, Q&A

Capitalization: Headlines, Subheads and Job Titles

Documents and web copy.

Our documents, web copy, presentations and other assets all use a header hierarchy to relate information in an organized, manageable way.

H1: Title Case

H2-H5: Following a header, all subsequent subheads must be in sentence case, with a full stop at the end. Capitalize only the first word and any proper names and nouns that appear. Wherever possible, subheads should be a full sentence.

> Example:

H1: How To Support Emotional Wellness in the Workplace

H2: 1. Communicate about your company's Employee Assistant Programs.

[copy block]

H2: 2. Normalize taking breaks away from your desk.

[copy block]

H2: 3. Allow employees to take mental health days.

[copy block]

H2: 4. Train managers to listen to their team and recognize emotional stress.

[copy block]

The following words should always be capitalized in titles:

- From
- To
- Is

NOTE: For presentations, match the titles and capitalization examples within the PowerPoint template.

Job titles.

Use initial caps but lowercase all general job categories.

Examples:

- Jane Doe, VP of Marketing at ABC Company
- John Smith, a supervisor at ABC Company

Citations, Footnotes and References

When speaking to data from internal or external sources, use citations to showcase where that information came from. Use only trustworthy sources.

We use the note system and sequential superscript numbers as keys to reference material and other content sources, placed in notes at the bottom of each page, or footnotes.

Where to put the superscript in running copy.

Whenever possible, put each superscript immediately after the end of the sentence or section containing the material cited. Use numeric footnotes in order of appearance.

Example:

WebMD's Lifestyle Coaching programs take acuity levels in a positive direction, as WebMD participant outcomes show.[1]

How to format footnotes.

- Begin citation reference with the source name followed by a period.
- Next, list the full document and end it with a period.
- If the document title also includes the year, end the citation with a period after the title name, and add the year followed by another period.

Examples:

Materials produced by WebMD Health Services:

WebMD Health Services. 2015 Book of Business Metrics.

Materials from other organizational or corporate authors:

Blue Research®. WebMD Health Services Client Retention Survey. 2014.

Citing an online, externally facing resource:

NOTE: Make the title an active hyperlink to the online source.

NPR.org. Women Are Losing More Jobs in Coronavirus Shutdowns. April 8, 2020.

For presentations.

In presentations, you do not need to use footnotes with superscript numbers. Instead, simply list the sources cited on each slide at the bottom of each slide.

Examples:

Source: 2015 Book of Business Metrics.

Source: NPR.org. Women Are Losing More Jobs in Coronavirus Shutdowns. April 8, 2020.

For blog copy.

Blog copy uses a healthy mix of both citations and footnotes, and anchor text and hyperlinks, to cite our sources. This helps gain trust while also minimizing lengthy phrasing within what should be easy-to-digest content. For example, using citations minimizes the usage of "according to this study" phrases.

Example:

The Labor Department says more than 700,000 jobs were eliminated in the first wave of

---

[1] Example of where to insert the superscript and footnote.

pandemic layoffs in March; women held nearly 60% of those jobs.[2] Women tend to work in sectors of the economy that were hardest hit, like leisure and hospitality, educational and health services, retail, and professional and business services.[3]

Clichés and Filler Words

Avoid using clichés, tired language, or filler words. Instead, be more strategic in the story you are telling.

Examples of clichés include phrases like:

- from _____ to _____
- whether _____ or _____
- rest assured
- now more than ever
- in order to
- with that being said
- for all intents and purposes

Most of the time, we also avoid over-the-top superlatives unless we can prove it. Examples include:

- World-class
- Best-in-class
- Premier
- Unique

Clients: How To Refer To Clients and Their Organizations

Clients.

Refer to our clients as clients. Never refer to them as customers or consumers.

In writing, refer to clients by their full name in the first instance. If they have an abbreviated name—including acronyms used by the client to refer to itself—use them in subsequent mentions.

> Example: ABC Company is a long-standing WebMD client. In the last 12 years, the WebMD-ABC partnership has delivered meaningful and measurable improvements in the well-being of

---

[2] NPR.org. Women Are Losing More Jobs in Coronavirus Shutdowns. April 8, 2020.
[3] Institute for Women's Policy Research. Quick Figures. April 2020.

thousands of ABC participants.

Clients' organizations.

When referring to our clients' populations, we use specific terms for employers and health plans.

Employers: Refer to their population as employees.

Example: Thirty percent of your employees completed the ONE Assessment in February.

Health Plans: Refer to their population as members.

Example: The data shows incredible success in member engagement.

Employers *and* Health Plans: When speaking about both populations, refer to them as individuals or your organization or your population(s).

Example: Stress can directly affect your organization's physical health. Your individuals may benefit from more communications around your stress management programs.

Participant

We use the term participant when referring to an employee, health plan member, or beneficiary of the clients purchasing and using solutions from WebMD Health Services. Also, when appropriate, the following terms can be used: employee, beneficiary, member, population.

Do NOT use the terms client or end-user when referring to the consumer.

Dashes: Em-Dash vs. En-Dash

We use an em-dash (—) to indicate a long or dramatic pause or shift. Do not add space before and after the dash.

Examples:

- Volunteering together is a great way to combat loneliness—even if it's done remotely!
- Changes to the process will prompt program administrators to use a second form of identification—either a downloadable application or an SMS text message—when logging in.

NOTE: We do not use the en-dash (–). Avoid overuse of the em-dash to set off phrases when commas would suffice.

Latin Terms and Abbreviations

We do not use e.g. or i.e. or etc. in our content. Instead, use the following words:

- For e.g.: for example *or* such as

- For i.e.: that is *or* specifically
- For etc.: and other

Lists: Bulleted Lists, Numbered Lists and Punctuation Rules

Typically, introduce bulleted lists with an introduction and a colon. Capitalize the first letter in each bullet or number. Follow a parallel structure for each item in a list.

Only include periods if the items within each bullet or number are complete sentences, or if the introductory phrase plus the phrases in the list equal a complete sentence. Note that in the latter instance, the bulleted items should be four or more words each.

Example:

WebMD's five dimensions of well-being include:

1. Physical fitness
2. Emotional balance
3. Social connections
4. Financial security
5. Clinical management

Example:

WebMD's differentiators are as follows:

- We are the pioneers in behavior change.
- We drive deeper connections through segmentation and personalization.
- We inspire healthy decisions every day through unrivaled service.
- We have demonstrated the value of our programs.
- We have brand awareness, which transcends to implicit trust with consumers.

Example:

Our data and analytics services can help identify:

- Which segments of your population may need support with specific wellness initiatives.
- Which times of the year you may need to increase communications for higher engagement rates.
- The ROI and VOI of a person-first, digital-first wellness solution.

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Parentheses

We **do not** use parentheses to convey important information in most instances, as research shows that many users skip over information contained within them. Instead, use commas, semicolons, bulleted lists or em-dashes to convey your point.

> **Example:** Losing weight—even a small amount—can have positive effects on mood, energy levels and sleep quality.

We only use parentheses when:

- Using an acronym.
  - **Example:** Wash your hands for at least 20 seconds, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC).
- Relating percentages or other insightful data.
  - **Example:** Nearly half (45%) of adults in the U.S. report that their mental health has been negatively impacted due to worry and stress over the pandemic.

Serial Comma

We **do not** use the serial comma in a simple series.

> **Example:** WebMD Health Services is thoughtful, dedicated and strategic.

However, we do use the serial comma in a complex series of phrases and in cases where omitting the final comma would make the meaning unclear.

> **Example:** WebMD Health Services strives to help employers and health plans increase retention, engagement, and productivity, and help decrease overall health costs.

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Glossary of Terms and Appropriate Use Cases A-Z

This section provides information on rules we use for words, terms and elements. It is not intended to be an exhaustive list. If you have any questions or need further guidance, please email branding@webmdhealthservices.com.

A

Affect vs. Effect

Affect (verb): to influence.

> Example: Mental health affects physical health.

Affect (noun): Occasionally used in psychology to describe an emotion. As there is no need for this version in everyday language, it's best to avoid this use case.

Effect (verb): to cause.

> Example: Stress has negative effects on your population's overall well-being.

Effect (noun): result, consequence.

> Example: Jane Doe's participation in the steps challenge had positive effects on her overall well-being.

B

book of business

WebMD's roster of clients.

To refer to WebMD's metrics from its book of business, use the complete name of the document.

> Example: WebMD Health Services. 2015 Book of Business Metrics.

Clinical Advisory Board

Spell out our Clinical Advisory Board, with title caps, in all instances.

> Example: At WebMD Health Services, our trusted Clinical Advisory Board validates every one of our products and services.

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D

diabetes

Specify the type of diabetes where relevant or necessary, such as when discussing specific treatments. Never refer to type 1 diabetes as juvenile diabetes, as this term is outdated.

> Examples: Type 1 diabetes, Type 2 diabetes, prediabetes.

disease names

Capitalize the proper noun portion only if the disease is named after a person or geographical area.

> Examples: Parkinson's disease, Crohn's disease, Alzheimer's disease, cancer, emphysema, leukemia, hepatitis, arthritis, pneumonia.
>
> > Do NOT use expressions like the following: He suffers from Alzheimer's disease. He is battling cancer. She is a stroke victim.
> >
> > Instead, use neutral and precise descriptions like the following: He has stomach cancer. She had a stroke.

E

e-book

Always use the hyphen. Do not capitalize the E or the B unless this word is being used in a headline or as part of a title.

> Example of title: E-Book: How To Plan and Implement an Employee Engagement Program
>
> Example of body copy: Our range of e-books includes information on engagement, reporting, culture ideas and more.

email

Do not use a hyphen for this term.

H

healthcare

Write healthcare as one word, without a hyphen, in all instances.

O

offsite, onsite

Write these terms as one word, without a hyphen, in all instances.

> Example: offsite meeting, onsite wellness staff

P

personally identifiable information

Spell out the full term in the first instance, followed by PII in parentheses. Then, use PII in subsequent instances.

> Example: We take extra security measures to ensure your organization's personally identifiable information (PII) remains protected. One step we take to protect PII includes enabling multi-factor authentication.

preventive

We use the term preventive, NOT preventative.

protected health information

Spell out the full term in the first instance, followed by PHI in parentheses. Then, use PHI in subsequent instances.

> Example: Multi-factor authentication helps keep your organization's protected health information (PHI) secure. Tools where PHI is accessible, such as the Customer Service Tool, will require multi-factor authentication in Fall 2020.

S

single sign-on

Spell out the full term in the first instance, followed by SSO in parentheses. Then, use SSO in subsequent instances.

> Example: With single sign-on (SSO), your members can easily navigate between benefits and vendors without having to log in to each platform every time. SSO allows for a seamless user experience.

V

versus

Use the full word in ordinary speech and writing. In headlines, charts, tables, presentations and callouts, use vs.—with a period—to convey your point.

> Example of ordinary writing: Today, we'll look at financial wellness versus physical wellness and their overall impact on health.
>
> Example of a headline: Financial Wellness vs. Physical Wellness

W

web, website

Both instances are OK to use. When referring to our website, use all lowercase and remove the "www" prefix.

> Example: To make the most of your well-being programs, go to webmdhealthservices.com.

WebMD Health Services

Use the full company name in the first instance and when it is necessary to provide a distinction between WebMD Health Services and WebMD.com. In subsequent instances, use WebMD.

Do NOT use WHS.

> Example: WebMD Health Services is a well-being company.

wellness vs. well-being

Wellness

Wellness refers to one aspect of overall well-being. For example, financial wellness is one dimension of well-being.

Wellness challenges

Use the term wellness challenge when referring to our solutions. Use the full term in the first instance, and vary between the shorter term "challenges" and the full term "wellness challenge" in subsequent instances.

> Example: Some of our wellness challenges incorporate gamification to increase engagement and drive behavior change. For example, The Invitational Team Steps Challenge is a steps-based challenge that places participants on teams and matches them up against a competing team

each week. The goal of this **wellness challenge** is to get consumers moving in a fun, proactive way that encourages peer-based support.

NOTE: **Do NOT** refer to them as well-being challenges in any instance.

Well-being

Well-being refers to a holistic view of wellness, where one aspect of wellness can impact other dimensions. For example, all our wellness solutions make up our overall well-being experiences.

Use the term **well-being** when:

- Referring to all the dimensions together.
- Referring to the desired consumer state.
- Talking about the industry in which we operate.
    - **Example:** WebMD Health Services is a well-being company.
    - **Example:** WebMD Health Services provides well-being experiences that drive behavior change.

When writing **well-being**, follow these rules:

Always hyphenate the term well-being. In titles, capitalize the W and the B.

Example of a title: How To Incorporate Five Dimensions of Well-Being

Examples of wellness versus well-being use cases:

- WebMD helped ABC Company create and implement **wellness challenges** that advanced its **well-being** strategy and outcomes.
- Our **wellness challenges** focus on specific areas of **well-being** for dedicated periods of time. Challenges encourage people to take steps toward better and ongoing **well-being** on their own or as part of a team.